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The structure of Kanuri society

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For reasons of residence, inheritance and legal responsibility, ties with the father's and mother's kin are of a different kind. The high proportion of patrilocal marriages as well as the differential division of inheritance as between males and females on the one hand and agnatic and uterine kin on the other in Maliki law tends to emphasize the father's agnatic group as the more important. ⁽¹⁾ It is also the agnatic kin of the father who go to court to support ego and who help him to pay fines.

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Terms of reference are most generally formed from the terms of address by adding the possessive pronoun at the end of the word. Thus ya (mother) can be yanyi (my mother) or yanum (your mother) or yanz[unknown] (his/her mother). Due to the reciprocal nature of the joking relationship between grandparent and grandchild, the term of address (grandparent speaking) is kaka, and is used reciprocally, while the differentiated term for grandchild (diwo) is used primarily [52](#) as a term of reference. The terms given in the appendix for full and half-siblings are only very rarely used as terms of reference, and never in addressing the person involved. The polite and proper behaviour being the use of sibling terms, and if finer distinctions become necessary, the relationship is referred to descriptively, a very common practice in referring to kinship relations. Informants claimed that the "real" term for ego's father's other wives is ya chintu (far mother) and its reciprocal

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is tada chintu (far child, male). However, the term is considered derogatory, even in reference, and would only be utilized if there were well developed antagonism between the actors. Ego, in order to be polite, should use the terms of reference and address for Fa-Sis, when speaking of or to his father's other wives. On the other hand, these latter women will never speak of ego as tadanyi (my child, male) as the real Fa-Sis might easily do, but refer to ego as tada kwanyi (my husband's child). The only time the rule is broken is when ego's mother dies and he is adopted by one of his mother's co-wives. Then she is called either ya (mother) or the Fa-Sis term is kept in use, and ego may now be referred to as tadanyi (my male child) by his father's other wife. The same thing occurs between ego and his mother's other husbands besides ego's father. There are reciprocal terms which are derogatory and indicate bad feeling between the parties if they are used - aba chintu (far father) and again tada chintu (far child, male) - whereas rawa (Mo-Bro) is the polite term unless ego wishes to insult his mother's husband. The reciprocally polite term is tada kamunyi (my wife's child, male) or tada k[unknown]raminyi (my Yosibling's male child).

Ruxton, F.H.; Maliki Law, (London) 1914, pp. 373-397.

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